You Can’t Take The Sky From Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61569871.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - College/University, Dating, Totalitarian State, SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Collections:
SPOP Flex Secret Solstice, SPOP Creative Flex

Stats:
Published: 2024-12-24 Words: 3,439 Chapters: 1/1

You Can’t Take The Sky From Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61569871.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - College/University, Dating, Totalitarian State, SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Collections:
SPOP Flex Secret Solstice, SPOP Creative Flex

Stats:
Published: 2024-12-24 Words: 3,439 Chapters: 1/1

You Can’t Take The Sky From Me

by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

“Oh em gee, you actually have a newspaper. What year is it, 2005?”

“Wouldn’t be necessary if they didn’t ban phones inside the university. Look.”

“‘Fire in the night: docked ship engulfed in flames’,” Adora read out. “A ship caught on fire?”

“Somebody *set* a ship on fire,” Glimmer corrected.

OR

The totalitarian state AU

Notes

Written for ChaoticAroAce as part of the 2024 Flex Solstice Swap.

I hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the work for more notes

"Check *this* out."

Mermista barely had time to move her lunch tray out of the way before Glimmer slapped the paper down in the middle of the table, scattering an empty milk carton to the floor and getting the corner in Adora's soup, much to her dismay.

"Oh em gee, you actually have a newspaper," Mermista drawled. "What year is it, 2005?"

"Wouldn't be necessary if they didn't ban phones inside the university," Glimmer huffed. "Look."

Mermista, Catra and Adora all leaned in curiously. "'Fire in the night: docked ship engulfed in flames'," Adora read out. "A ship caught on fire?"

"Somebody *set* a ship on fire," Glimmer corrected.

"It doesn't say that, Sparkles," Catra retorted, still reading.

"Well, *duh*, they'd never admit to it, but it's true. There's no way this just randomly happens."

"Who'd want to set a ship on fire?" Adora asked.

"Somebody with a pair on them, that's who. It was a patrol boat, you see?" Glimmer leaned in conspiratorially, lowering her voice. "People are fighting *back*."

"Great. Happy for them." Mermista peevishly pushed the paper away with her lunch tray. "Now the docks are gonna be swarming with cops every evening. I'm *thrilled*."

"Or they'll lower the curfew," Adora sighed. "Our mother already flips whenever we stay out past sunset."

"Stop calling her our mother," Catra muttered.

"Ugh, quit your moping," Glimmer groused. "This is a good thing!"

Mermista raised her eyebrows at Glimmer. "Because our lives will be so much better now that there's one less police boat."

"It's about the message it sends! We can't just keep letting the Prime Minister do as he pleases." Glimmer's voice was intense, now. "Did you know, in Dryl, they allow you to drink alcohol when you're sixteen years old, instead of eighteen? And in Halfmoon, there isn't a curfew at all! People stay out the entire night, doing whatever the hell they want."

"Now *that's* a life," Catra said wistfully.

Adora frowned. "Why would you want to stay up all night?"

Catra turned on her, smirking. "I can think of a few things, like a few nights ago, when we—"

Adora blushed fiercely, making a grab at the other girl. "*Catra*!"

But Catra nimbly danced away, spreading her arms in challenge. "Come on, Princess, is that the best you've got?"

On cue, Catra darted off and Adora gave chase. Mermista watched them go with a roll of the eyes. In the distance, one of the university supervisors shouted after them, "No running!"

"If I ever get the hots for my sister," Mermista said to Glimmer, "shoot me."

"They're both adopted, actually. Not related."

"Oh. Huh."

"Wait, you've got a sister?"

"Plural, out the wazoo. They had the foresight to ditch Salineas years ago, though."

"Figures I've never seen them." Glimmer's eyes darted past Mermista. "Now there's something I want to keep me up all night,"

she said in a low voice.

Mermista casually pretended to take something out of her schoolbag, inconspicuously scanning the cafeteria.

“What, Lonnie Davis?”

“*No*. Well, her too, maybe, but sitting next to her.”

Mermista dared another glance.

“Mr. Muscle?”

“Oh yes. I think his name’s Bow. Starla said he’s an ancient histories major.” Glimmer waggled her eyebrows. “Time to make some history with him.”

“Good luck,” Mermista muttered, deadpan, as Glimmer abandoned their table, leaving just her on her ownsome.

But not for long.

“Do forgive the interruption, only it seems to me you have been deserted in your hour of need.” A large shadow fell over her. “But fret not! Here I am to remedy your predicament!”

Mermista let out a long-suffering sigh, leaning on her fist as Sebastian Hawk, inexplicably known as Sea Hawk, entered her field of vision. “What do you want, Sebastian?”

“To offer my most humble apologies for the little mishap on our last date. Behold!” Sea Hawk adjusted the tie of his ill-fitting school uniform and revealed a bouquet of wildflowers from behind his back. “A token of my sincerity, one whose natural charms pale in comparison to yours, but may very well compliment them!”

“Our last date? You mean when you started dancing on the counter and got us kicked out?” Mermista scoffed, snatching the bouquet from him. “Where’d you get these?”

Sea Hawk rubbed his chin. “Mh, I stole them out of Miss Weaver’s garden.”

“Of course you did.” Mermista decided to leave them on the table, levelling Sea Hawk with what she knew was her unparalleled stare of boredom. “They’re okay, I guess.”

Sea Hawk primed his finger. “Ah! But here is my two-pronged attack, for now I must beg you for a second chance. Perhaps… dinner at the Smeltery?”

“Depends. Is it another karaoke pub?”

“*Not* by design!”

Mermista sighed. “Fine. Why the hell not.”

“I. Can’t. Believe. You.”

“Mermista. *Dearest* Mermista, you have to understand that it was imperative for me to defend your honour!”

Sea Hawk was struggling to keep pace with Mermista as she power walked down the street, collar pulled up, *away* from the Smeltery and *away* from him.

“You started a fight with the maître d’ for approaching a different table. How is that *defending my honour*?”

“I thought he was snubbing you!”

“They arrived before us,” Mermista enunciated deliberately.

“An honest mistake…”

“You *slapped* him.”

"I admit, I may have been a tad overzealous…"

Mermista whirled on him, jabbing a finger in his chest. "*Overzealous*? You embarrassed me, dude. Like, royally. I won't be able to show my face there for a year."

"A few months, at best!"

Mermista raised an unimpressed eyebrow at him.

"At least let me drive you home?"

"Yeah, no. We're done." Mermista turned away, raising her hand. "Taxi!"

She left him on the sidewalk while she went back to her studio apartment. She should've known better than to give that madcap a second chance. The signs were all there for her to read.

Still, it was a shame. Mermista *had* hoped it would've been a candlelit dinner with dessert type of evening. Now she supposed it would simply have to be a frozen pizza and soaking in the bathtub for an hour kind of evening.

She just *really* wished he wasn't her type.

A few weeks later…

"Jesus fucking Christ—okay, listen to this," Glimmer said, clutching a small square booklet Mermista figured wasn't at all one of the state-sanctioned newspapers. "'Henceforth, Prime Minister Vince Horner and any of his cabinet members will be able to appoint and dismiss teachers across primary education, secondary education, and institutions of higher learning.' They get *final say* in who does or doesn't teach! Now all our professors are gonna be

walking around on eggshells, afraid they'll lose their tenure!" She tossed the booklet down with an angry grunt. "This is *bullshit*."

"That's not all," Bow said, picking at his blouse uncomfortably. Glimmer had sunk her proverbial talons in, and now the boy had become a permanent fixture of their table the past few weeks. "We're not allowed to gather in groups larger than five, outside of our classes."

"Kinda makes you wonder what's next," Mermista said, turning a page of the murder mystery novel she was only half-reading. "Next thing you'll know they'll start banning books."

"A university that *bans books*?" Glimmer scoffed loud enough for a few heads to turn at the neighbouring tables. "*Surely*, at some point, self-awareness comes into it? Like they're forced to take a long, hard look at themselves and go 'oh wait, this is the stupidest fucking thing ever.'"

Mermista shrugged. "You'd think so. Still, Wouldn't even be surprised if it happened."

"But I daresay *I* may surprise you yet!" Sea hawk swooped in like a hurricane, propping himself between Mermista and Adora. "For I have acquired not one, but *two* tickets to Lynda D'Ream's concert, one night only, down at the Enchanted Grotto!" He flashed two tickets and fluttered his eyelashes fiercely. "Might this interest you, oh dearest Mermista?"

Mermista groaned. "Seriously? I already gave you a second chance. What makes you think you deserve a third?"

"Because, as they say, third time's the charm!"

"Well I think Mermista would *love* to go to the concert with you," Glimmer cut in before Mermista could deliver a scathing retort.

"Oh yes, she's been *dying* to see Lynda," Catra enjoined, flashing Mermista a devious smirk.

“Excellent!” Sea Hawk pumped his fist in the air jubilantly. “You may expect me outside your door at seven!”

“Wait— how do you know where I live?”

“Perfuma told me!” Sea Hawk beamed, then glanced at Bow. “Oh, hi Bow!”

Bow gave a little wave, smiling timidly. “Hey, Hawk.”

“No groups larger than five!” a university supervisor yelled across the room. “Disperse!”

“That is my cue to leave. Ta-ta!” And before Mermista could say anything else, Sea Hawk was already striding off like he was practising for the marching band.

She scowled at the rest of the table. “Great. *Thanks* for that, guys.”

Glimmer shrugged. “If you don’t want to go that badly, better call it off while you can.”

Mermista slumped against the table, huffing.

“Nah, too much effort.”

Next week…

“So… I hear your date went well,” Adora probed.

“Which part?” Mermista groused. “The part where he spilled his drink on Lynda D’Ream’s dress, or the part where *three* different people tried to fight him?”

“What’d they wanna fight him for?”

Mermista shrugged at Glimmer. "Fuck if I know. Maybe he owes them money. Maybe he lit their shit on fire. But they all knew where to find him."

"Sounds like somebody ratted him out," Catra said, pointedly glaring at Adora. "*Hate* when that happens."

"Well *maybe* he should've have been more careful!" Adora retorted loudly, side-eyeing Catra.

Mermista arched an eyebrow, shifting her attention to Glimmer. "What's their deal?"

"Catra brought a knife to the university," Glimmer muttered. "Adora told their mom."

"She's not our fucking mom," Catra hissed.

Mermista's eyes widened. "Jesus, dude. Why'd you do that?"

"It was a Stanley knife *from* the university!" Catra threw her hands up. "Literally who gives a fuck? Besides, have you *seen* the neighbourhood we live in?"

"You could've gotten in trouble with the staff!" Adora said frantically, all of them whisper-shouting. "You *know* they would've gone straight to the police!"

"I *did* get in trouble." Catra abruptly stood up, snatching her bookbag with her. "You think Weaver didn't come at me?"

"Well—then what'd Weaver do!?"

"Oh, *fuck off*, idiot," Catra spat, storming off.

"Catra, wait!"

Mermista and Glimmer watched them run off. Glimmer sighed, rubbing her face.

“Where’d your boyfriend go?” Mermista asked, deciding to change subjects.

“He’s not my boyfriend!” Glimmer squeaked. “And… I don’t know! I haven’t seen him all week. His classmates said he hasn’t attended any of their last five lectures, which is weird, because he *was* here at the time…”

“So he’s dropping out.” Mermista shrugged. “Shame. You two were cute together.”

“I don’t know.” Glimmer frowned pensively. “It doesn’t make sense. Could you ask Sea Hawk about him for me?”

“You mean *willingly* approach the dude?”

“I’m giving you an excuse to,” Glimmer said, dead serious. “Come on, Mermista, for me? Pleaaase? I’ll buy you coffee for the rest of the week!”

“Ugh, *fine*,” Mermista pointed at Glimmer. “*And*, you’ll let me borrow your car this weekend. There’s this, like, huge sale in Seaworthy that I can *not* miss.”

“Deal!”

Sea Hawk wasn’t hard to find, naturally. All Mermista had to do was follow the raised voices and scent of trouble, leading her to a table of students in the process of getting scolded by one of the university supervisors.

“Mermista! Sweet, dearest Mermista!” Sea Hawk cried out as the supervisor strode off. “To what do I owe the unexpected pleasure? A second chance, perhaps? You won’t regret it!”

Mermista treated the rest of the table and their budding grins to a cold look, which proved enough to stifle their schadenfreude in its crib. “Yeah, pretty sure it’d be like your fifth chance at this point, Sebastian.”

"Second verse, same as the first!"

She rolled her eyes. "Look, have you seen Bow? Glimmer's worried, and it's seriously messing with my vibe."

Sea Hawk tugged at his tie. "Bow? No, not at all. I don't know where he is or what he's up to! I mean, why would I know what he's up to? I don't keep tabs on him at all. Definitely don't. I'm sure he's off doing… Bow… things…!"

Mermista stared flatly at him. A girl at his table facepalmed, muttering, "Smooth, dude."

Sea Hawk laughed nervously. "I mean, when I see him, I could pass on a message—I mean, *if* I see him! Which I haven't. At all! No siree."

"Okay, so you're acting way weirder than usual," Mermista huffed. "If you don't wanna tell me, just say so, but stop putting on this weird spiel."

"I'm… afraid I cannot help you!" Sea Hawk clasped a fist to his chest with Thespian flair. "I truly wish I could, but, alas…"

"Yeah, whatever dude. I'll let Glimmer know."

"Tarry a while, dear Mermista!" Sea Hawk cleared his throat. "Might I interest you in… tickets to Prince Peekablue's show? He's performing tonight, you see—"

"What, so you can get on stage with him and sing a sea shanty about me again? Or were you planning on getting into another fight?" She shook her head. "I'm done, dude. *Genuinely* done. And if you're gonna insult my intelligence by badly pretending you don't know where Bow is… yeah, I think I get where we stand. Bye."

She turned and walked off without a glance, hearing the defeated slump of Sea Hawk behind her.

“And?” Glimmer asked hopefully when she returned to their table. “Does he know where Bow is?”

“Apparently not.” Mermista folded her arms, deciding she earned some slumping over the table too. “And if he does, he’d certainly hate to tell me.”

Several weeks later…

Mermista jogged down the dark and rainy harbour street, muttering up a slew of pejoratives regarding her flat tire and the new curfew, now brought down to nine p.m. There was no way she was going to make it home before that, so at this point her main worry was avoiding the militant gazes of the state officers.

“…all know what is at stake here, so I won’t bore you…”

Mermista slowed. And stopped.

Like the seventy-six-millimeter cannons of a warship grinding into place, she turned towards the alleyway, locking eyes with none other than Sea Hawk.

Sea Hawk, dressed head to toe in black but for the red scarf stuffed into his collar.

Sea Hawk, joined by four other dark-clad figures, all wearing balaclavas.

A long silence followed. Mermista was the first to speak.

“O-kay. What the fuck.”

“M-Mermista!” Sea Hawk staggered forward, waving down his ominous colleagues. To their credit and Mermista’s mild surprise,

they appeared a great deal less anxious than Sea Hawk over having been spotted. "F-fancy seeing you here! May I say, the winter moonlight brings out your hair like a star reflected in the sea—"

Mermista angrily cut him off. "What the fuck are you *doing* here?"

"Merely a… nighttime stroll with like-minded… err…"

"You might as well tell her, Hawk," one of the figures behind him said in a muffled but *very* familiar voice.

"Glimmer?" Mermista mumbled, stupefied.

Glimmer pulled the balaclava off her head, her pink mop of hair popping out in a way that confirmed to Mermista not even a hurricane or a sand roller could force it out of shape. "Hey."

"And the rest of you…"

One by one, they pulled their masks off. Adora smiled sheepishly at her, Catra gave a little wave, while Bow stared at her with big, owlish eyes.

"Are you all, like, into organised crime?" Mermista narrowed her eyes at Adora. "Is that how you were able to afford a Mustang?"

"Inheritance," Adora mumbled.

"Not quite!" Sea Hawk puffed up excitedly. "Ours is a far more noble pursuit, taking the fight to the Prime Minister and his tyrannical autocracy!"

Mermista blinked. "You're… activists."

Sea Hawk dipped his chin. "In a word."

"Terrorists."

Glimmer frowned. "Honestly, that's a word in *their* vocabulary, not ours."

Adora nodded. “We prefer freedom fighters.”

“Agitators,” Catra added with a smirk.

“Rebels!” Sea Hawk finished.

Mermista stared, stunned. The silence as her mind worked to come to terms with the display before her lasted a second, yet felt like it stretched on forever, until Bow spoke up.

“Guys? We’re kind of… making a lot of noise? Maybe we should get going now.”

“Ah, but of course!” Sea Hawk stepped closer to Mermista. “Mermista, dearest, I must away now, but perhaps I can… persuade you into a complicit silence with a date? A night at the Drowning Dolphin, perhaps?”

Mermista shook her head. She had made her mind up.

“No.”

Catra tensed. Sea Hawk hesitated.

“No?”

Mermista grabbed Sea Hawk by the shoulders. “*No*. Are you kidding me? You want me to pretend I didn’t just find the five of you with crowbars and lighters in an alley? You want me to go on a date to the fucking *Drowning Dolphin* with you while you’re out here socking it to the man?” She took a deep breath. “Take me with you.”

“Really?” Glimmer asked.

“This is… one hell of a decision to make in an alleyway on a Thursday night,” Sea Hawk ventured. “Are you sure?”

“Yeah.” Mermista flipped her hair back. “You think I enjoy my home slowly getting turned into a dictatorship? I want in. On

whatever it is you're doing." She gestured to the cans of gasoline behind Catra. "Plus, you're clearly about to set some shit on fire, and I wanna see it."

The four exchanged a look. Adora smiled, Glimmer nodded to Bow, Catra rolled her eyes and gave a shrug, while Sea Hawk's face seemed to light up like a Christmas tree. He stuck out his hand.

"Welcome aboard, Mermista."

Mermista erred, then took his hand to grip it firmly. Not really what she expected, but she supposed it fit the accession.

"Let's get you something dark. We've got a facility to smash up."

The salty spray of the sea stung Mermista's face as Sea Hawk's speedboat, the *Dragon's Daughter III*, sliced through the waves—a cold reminder of what she had gotten herself into, even if she was still being pulled into the high of her decision's vertigo.

They had swaddled her in one of Adora's extra coats and given her a pair of thin black winter gloves, figuring that would have to do for their mission, which was…

"There's a factory here where they make all sorts of crap," Glimmer explained for the second time that night. "Drones, pilotless aircraft, long-range espionage tech, the lot of it. We'll bust up as much as we can, paint the outside red and light it up." She slapped the buckets of paint at her and Bow's feet. "Seven minutes, in and out. Easy as pie."

Mermista looked to her other side. Catra and Adora, snug together with looks of grim determination on their faces. The two of them

had apparently resolved their differences regarding the knife incident.

And next to her, steering the boat, Sebastian Hawk, the fool who turned out to be way more than meets the eye.

He caught her eye. "How are you feeling, Mermista? No second thoughts?"

"None whatsoever." And Mermista was surprised to realise she wasn't lying. She didn't have second thoughts at all. Not on stepping onboard with these students-turned-rebels, not with the prospect of setting a government facility on fire… and not with doing it alongside Sea Hawk.

Together with Sea Hawk.

"I'm glad." Sea Hawk smiled, small and genuine. "Know that your presence at my side instils in me a confidence hitherto undreamt of. I've always had the greatest of confidences in my strangely qualified crew here, but now… No, I doubt I'll be about this quest with even the least bit of trepidation, with you here—"

Mermista rolled her eyes, grabbing his free hand to interrupt him.

"Oh, shut up, dork."

"We're getting close!" Bow called.

"Mask up, you jacktars, mask up! Let us do some good for Etheria's sake!"

The rest of the crew pulled their balaclavas back over their heads. Mermista reached for hers, exchanging one more look with Sea Hawk. He grinned, and Mermista couldn't hope to repress her own smile. She pulled the balaclava over her head and watched as he took position on the speedboat's bow, striking his arm out towards the factory on the horizon.

"Onwards, to adventure!"

End Notes

Merry Christmas, God Jul and happy holidays everyone!

Work title is from the Ballad of Serenity by Sonny Rhodes.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!